

Chapter 83 - Death

The sword's edge pierced into her heart and was pulled out, blood splashing three feet. Mei Chengsi had never thought this sword would stab into his own heart. He stretched out his hand, staring at Ning Fuyi with eyes wide in fury, fresh blood gurgling from his mouth.

He didn't close his eyes even in death.

Hong Ying and Feng Ge stumbled out from the shattered hall, and what they saw was this scene. Terrified, they clutched each other, covering their mouths and not daring to approach.

The woman's green robe was stained with blood, her posture upright yet like a life-claiming fierce ghost. The divine sword, clear as jade powder, was soaked in fresh blood that dripped from its tip.

"Ning, Ning Fuyi..." Feng Ge retreated repeatedly, his gaze shifting to Rong Jin who had already lost consciousness, his knees weakening and nearly collapsing.

The power triggered by rage surged within Ning Fuyi's body. Long-absent hatred filled her chest, and the satisfaction of slaughter impacted her mind. She seemed to once again stand in the cold, dark previous life, with blood-stained rivers and mountains beneath her feet.

She raised her sword again.

Just then, several dog barks sounded behind her. Ping'an, with one lame leg, somehow emerged from the ruins, tugging at her hem and barking frantically.

Wind carrying sand struck her face, the earth-shaking sound returned to her ears, and clarity returned to Ning Fuyi's mind.

Chu Qingqiu... she had to find Chu Qingqiu!

"Help me watch over Senior Brother Rong Jin." Ning Fuyi's voice was hoarse as she spoke, not looking at the dead Mei Chengsi again, stepping on her sword and leaping into the night sky.

It was merely heaven and earth being unkind, no matter. She still had Chu Qingqiu.

Someone as powerful as Chu Qingqiu would never come to harm. She had finally found everything back and would never lose it again.

Even if Chu Qingqiu had no heart, as long as Chu Qingqiu was still alive, this world wouldn't be so terrible.

She used all her strength to control the sword and finally saw the hazy night shadows of Jingshan Palace¹. She secretly harbored hope, but that bit of relief was soon shattered by crying shouts. She saw several figures floating in the night, continuously using immortal power to strike and try to break the barrier, but to no avail.

The one shouting was Liu Wenzhu, repeatedly striking the barrier with her thousand-pound hammer, only to be bounced back again and again.

"Chief Elder, Elder Jingshan, this barrier was set by the demon clan. Our immortal power truly cannot break it. We can only first remove the illusion spell upon it to see the Divine Venerable's condition clearly!" Elder Pingyao's clothes were torn, she swept her hair behind her and formed an array in mid-air.

Several elders heard this and also stood up, surrounding and sitting cross-legged in a circle above, their ten fingers drawing identical gestures. Light bands surged from their palms, outlining a magic array.

With their unified shout, the array descended upon the barrier. The barrier was like a dusty glass cover, washed clean from top to bottom, revealing the shocking scene within.

That swaying, frail yet steadily standing graceful figure was finally exposed before everyone's eyes.

Ning Fuyi trembled as she stopped, glaring hatefully at that figure who never looked back. Her five fingers clenched her chest clothes, which somehow hurt terribly, making her want to cry.

"Divine Venerable!" Several elders shouted, trying once more to break the barrier, but it was like a copper wall and iron fortress - they couldn't advance a single step.

"Father..." Liu Wenzhu had no strength left. She knelt powerlessly on her sword, continuously patting that layer of membrane that seemed forever impenetrable.

The person inside seemed unable to hear the commotion outside, or perhaps heard it but had no time to spare even half a response.

Lightning and white light collided repeatedly. Jingshan Palace had long been destroyed, pavilions and towers turned to ruins, the nine-curved corridors sunk into the water.

The completely irrational demon laughed hoarsely in mid-air. His body already had several bleeding holes emitting black qi, while Chu Qingqiu and the others were also wounded everywhere. Jiang Li, with the lowest cultivation, had already vomited blood several times and was now forcibly sustaining herself with handful after handful of pills.

"With just you few still wanting to kill me? Dream on! Even if the entire Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate came here today, to me they'd be nothing but a bunch of ants!" The man raised his arms, "Chu Qingqiu, you think breaking my array can stop me? Overestimating yourself!"

Chu Qingqiu's shoulders slightly contracted, her long hair flying freely in the wind without restraint, her jade-white cheeks soaked in crimson. She gripped the white bone tightly for support, her pupils reflecting the cold light of lightning.

The white clothes on her body were torn in many places, white silk and red blood entangled in the wind, broken like the magnificent palace beneath her feet.

She suddenly released her grip. The white bone, the magical artifact that had followed her to heaven and earth, spun and fell, growing larger and longer as it fell, finally driving deep into the ground like a pillar. Immediately, the earth shook and mountains trembled, causing movement for thousands of miles around. Wild beasts fled, and ten thousand birds took flight.

When the bone fell as signal, the Waning Moon Array rose.

"No..." Ning Fuyi murmured, the red in her eyes deepening. She suddenly raised Xiangsi², stabbing forcefully at the barrier, only to be bounced back. Blood seemed to cost nothing as it flowed from her mouth.

"Ning Fuyi, this barrier cannot be broken even by us several people. How could you break it! Quickly move away and don't waste your strength!" Elder Pingyao shouted hoarsely, "The Divine Venerable will be fine!"

How could someone so formidable escape unharmed? If she would be fine, why had she never once looked back at her from beginning to end?

Ning Fuyi struck at the barrier again. Heavy internal injuries combined with splitting headaches - for a moment she felt as if she was about to be torn in half.

She suddenly remembered something, cutting her wrist with a wave of her hand and squeezing out fresh blood, sprinkling it drop by drop on the barrier.

"Chu Qingqiu! Look at how unkind this world you protect is! Look at what kind of wolf-hearted, dog-lunged bunch you're protecting!" Ning Fuyi half-knelt on her divine sword, her voice carrying a crying tone, "Look at what kind of monster I am that you're protecting..."

"If you truly die, I'll continue to hate you. I'll imprison your corpse and dig up your grave. I'll have you stay by my side day and night to suffer my torment!" Ning Fuyi's words were utterly vicious, forcing her to look back just once.

But Chu Qingqiu didn't. She still stood heartlessly with her back to her in the wind. The four people at her feet responded by forming an array, bright moonlight emerging from within the array, enveloping Chu Qingqiu's entire body. Thus heaven and earth became vast and white, and everyone lost their vision.

The blood finally melted a gap in the demon clan barrier. Ning Fuyi tumbled into the barrier, but at the same time, a clear sound of silk thread snapping rang in her mind.

Ning Fuyi tremblingly raised her hand, watching the red rope she had never paid attention to begin flickering before finally disappearing without a trace.

The marriage contract was dissolved.

The light faded, and a gardenia flower shadow as enormous as Jingshan Palace rose from the earth's heart. The flower's center enveloped the woman's form and rushed toward the demon clan. Thus painful screams shook the mountains and rivers, and in an instant, blood mist flew to the sky, dyeing even the overhead dark clouds crimson.

The demon clan's desperate yet resentful voice suddenly rang in everyone's ears, exactly like an ancient corpse that had slept for a thousand years: "Chu Qingqiu, I want you to turn into dust and mud with your divine soul completely destroyed. I want the entire Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate to be buried with me."

Thus two heavenly thunderbolts fell from the dark clouds - one striking toward Chu Qingqiu, the other expanding in mid-air, intending to split the entire immortal mountain.

Ning Fuyi had no time to think and desperately flashed to stand before the now-silent Chu Qingqiu, wanting to block that heavenly thunder for her. However, a figure emerged from the ruins and stopped at the same time as her.

Finally, she heard a scolding voice. That person kicked her in the back, Ning Fuyi's chest felt stuffy with pain as she crashed into Chu Qingqiu.

"I am Master's disciple. To die for her, you're still not..."

The words stopped abruptly. Thus rolling thunder and lightning exploded behind her, splashing hot blood all over her.

Ning Fuyi seemed stunned for many years before reaching out to pull Chu Qingqiu's falling corpse into her arms, holding her tightly.

She was already completely numb, and for a moment couldn't distinguish what time it was. Chu Qingqiu's body still retained warmth, but no longer had a heartbeat.

Qiu Yi's body turned into blood mist scattered in the wind, two curved blades stuck in the mud.

Ning Fuyi slowly raised her head to look. Jiang Li had fainted on the ground, the remaining people all went to block the other heavenly thunder that was striking down. It seemed someone else had died - she heard Liu Wenzhu's familiar crying.

So she used her last bit of strength to release Xiangsi, throwing it out: "Help me."

Xiangsi divine sword finally rubbed against her cheek, then transformed into a shadow rushing toward the heavenly thunder. The enlarged divine sword's intent was gentle, and at the moment it collided with the heavenly thunder, the sword's cry resounded through heaven and earth.

Ning Fuyi no longer had any strength. She fell together with Chu Qingqiu's body, entangled as they rolled down.

However, after landing, the corpse she had desperately protected suddenly turned into sparkling dust particles, scattered by the wind. Only a jade bracelet and a cold stone remained in her palm.

The world rumbled chaotically, but she stared at the sky, gripping the stone, laughing until tears flowed down her face, laughing until black qi permeated around her body.

She had long been disappointed in this world. Only because someone had repeatedly protected her in this life did she rekindle hope, thinking this heaven and earth wasn't so bad after all.

She really wanted to be a good person in this lifetime. She wanted to be that small disciple of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate.

But now the person protecting her was dead again.

Chu Qingqiu, tell me, is this a natural disaster or man-made calamity? Is it fate or a terrible mistake?

Why, when starting over again, would life still be so bitter?

Ning Fuyi thought she would lose consciousness. How wonderful unconsciousness would be - it could temporarily help her escape this thorough joke and avoid facing those things that made her feel ridiculous.

But she didn't. She remained clearly aware, sitting on the ground, watching people come and go around her, watching someone place the now-lightless Xiangsi before her, watching Liu Wenhai's³ corpse being carried away, watching the unconscious Liu Wenzhu being escorted away by fellow disciples.

Someone helped her up and confined her in the ancestral hall. Some kind-hearted disciples secretly told her through the door cracks that Jiuying⁴ had been taken away by people from Penglai Realm⁵ and locked in a dungeon, whereabouts unknown.

Jiang Li was taken away overnight by the Jiang family for treatment. Rong Jin was being rescued by many medical immortals - whether he still had any chance of survival was unknown.

People continuously tried to snatch or trick away the stone in her palm, but no matter how others persuaded, she held onto that stone and wouldn't let go. Finally, everyone gave up.

After all, it was just a stone, not the Divine Venerable Chu Ling.

She heard that Elder Pingyao and other elders had spoken for her all night, saying she definitely wasn't from the demon clan, saying she killed Mei Chengsi to protect her senior brother, saying she had at least protected Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, but it all seemed useless.

After all, when those people said she was a demon, whether she was or wasn't, she was.

Ning Fuyi sat in the hall hugging her knees for one night. The next morning, the ancestral hall door finally opened. The one opening it was Elder Pingyao with a haggard face. She stood silently for a long while, then said sorry.

Ning Fuyi didn't speak, only smiled coldly. She watched those immortal soldiers walk toward her, putting black iron shackles on her hands and feet, taking her out of the hall under everyone's gaze.

After one night, the dark clouds had already dispersed. The long sky was clear and transparent as water, the bright sun hung high, brilliant sunlight illuminating her face.

Ning Fuyi ignored the whispers of surrounding disciples, raising her head to bathe in the sunlight.

Chu Qingqiu, if we can meet again in the next life, she must ask her one question.

If you see such a scene from heaven, would you feel as heartbroken as I do?

Would you regret it?

Footnotes:

1. **Jingshan Palace (静山宫)**: "Tranquil Mountain Palace" - the residence/temple of Chu Qingqiu
2. **Xiangsi (相思)**: "Mutual Longing/Lovesickness" - the name of Ning Fuyi's divine sword
3. **Liu Wenhai (柳闻海)**: Liu Wenzhu's father, an elder of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate
4. **Jiuying (九婴)**: "Nine Infants" - the nine-headed demon beast that contracted with Ning Fuyi
5. **Penglai Realm (蓬莱境)**: A major immortal sect/realm, one of the most powerful forces in the cultivation world